

Xiaoqing PAN

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Leibniz-Institut für Alternsforschung

Re: Research assistant

Dear Dr. Valenzano,

My name is Xiaoqing, I just finished my study at Hans-Knöll-Institute in Jena, Germany. I am writing to apply for the research assistant position in your lab.

I studied microbiology in the context of human fungal pathogens. My PhD project was focusing on double-stranded RNA metabolism in both humans and pathogenic fungi. I was elucidating how filamentous fungus *Aspergillus fumigatus* produces small RNAs, how dicer-like proteins process dsRNA substrates, and how excess dsRNA arrest fungal growth. I also combined bioinformatics (sRNA-seq and mRNA-seq analyses) and experimental validations (qPCR as well as Northern blot) to characterize the small RNA landscape and the contribution of RNAi machinery to fungal biology. This work has resulted in two publications on *RNA* and *Molecular microbiology*. In parallel, I was involved in another project investigating host transcriptomic responses. Through characterizing transcriptomic responses after fungal stimulations with a focus on host alternative splicing and A-to-I RNA editing, we surprisingly found out that *Rhizopus oryzae* can induce A-to-I editing as well as disrupt host RNA splicing. I contributed to analyse multiple RNA-seq cohorts, DEG analysis, alternative splicing analysis, RNA structure analysis and RNA editing analysis. Through my PhD training, I 've been equipped with solid wet-lab skills, such as fungi infecting human cell assay, microbial culturing, DNA/RNA extraction, and gained experiences on bioinformatics. I am currently writing a grant, which may be a long term process.

As my previous work was more molecular biology, I would like to take this opportunity to work with clinical samples/data. I like to manage in the lab as a clean, organized lab makes the work process more fluent. I have basic molecular biology background, such as qPCR, cloning, Northern/Western Blot, DNA/RNA extraction, culturing human cell line. I did immunofluorescent staining for human cell lines. I'm able to do RNA-seq from sample preparation to data analysis. I believe that bringing my perspective from fungal genetics and host-pathogen immunology could contribute fresh insights to related projects in the group.

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Best,

Xiaoqing

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SUMMARY

RNA biologist and computational transcriptomics researcher with expertise in high-throughput sequencing, gene regulation, and RNA-mediated cellular responses. Experienced in integrating molecular biology with bioinformatics to study small RNAs, RNA interference, alternative splicing, and RNA editing across host and microbial systems. Proficient in RNA-seq analysis, reproducible computational workflows (R, Bash), and sequencing-based approaches for investigating post-transcriptional regulation.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Molecular Biology:** sRNA cloning, NGS library preparation, GUS reporter assays, luciferase and GFP reporter assays, Gibson Assembly Cloning, Genetic Engineering, Northern Blot, qPCR, PCR, immunostaining, LC-MS, cultivation of microorganisms (BSL-1/2), plant cultivation and tissue preparation
- **Bioinformatics:** RNA-seq, sRNA-seq, differential expression, alternative splicing, small RNA characterization and target prediction, data visualization, HPC (Slurm), UCSC, SwissProt, KEGG, NCBI
- **Programming:** R, Python, Bash, Git, Docker, Linux
- **Language:** Chinese (native), English (fluent), German (B1)

EXPERIENCES

RNA landscape of human fungal pathogen *Aspergillus fumigatus*

- Characterized RNAi and tRNA fragments processing pathways in *A. fumigatus* across developmental stages (conidia, mycelium), revealing morphotype-specific RNA regulatory mechanisms
- Analyzed differential expressed genes on mRNA-, sRNA-seq datasets, uncovering post-transcriptional regulatory networks controlling fungal development and stress response.
- Validated genes of interest (sRNA, tRNA fragments, sRNA targets) via qPCR, northern blot

Human PBMC transcriptome changes upon fungal stimulations

- Analyzed pathogen-specific transcriptomic signatures in human immune cells responding to fungal pathogens, characterized differential expressed genes, alternative splicing, A-to-I RNA editing, pathogen recognition receptor pathway activation
- Built HPC pipeline, wrote custom R scripts for multi-condition cohort analysis

Human neutrophils exporting extracellular RNA upon *A. fumigatus* confrontation

- Analyzed EV-associated sRNA, tRNA, and mRNA cargo from primary human neutrophils during fungal challenge

Non-coding RNA analysis of rice-*Xanthomonas oryzae* interaction

- Studied how T3SS-dependent bacterial effectors from *Xanthomonas oryzae* shape host non-coding RNA regulation; performed GUS reporter assays, plant cultivation, tissue preparation, LC-MS, qPCR, and PCR
- Engineered overexpressed and knockout mutants of circular RNA and microRNA in rice, established genetic tools that enabled investigation of ncRNA-mediated regulation

Teaching

- Microbiology and Molecular Biology, MMB005, 2022-2025. Supervised master students investigating gene regulation together with Dr. Blango and other colleagues.

EDUCATION

PhD | Microbiology, Friedrich Schiller University, Germany (supervisor: Dr. Matthew Blango) 2026

Thesis: RNA regulation in host-fungal interactions: investigation of the host epitranscriptome and fungal small RNAs

MSc | Bioengineering, Chinese Academy of Sciences, China (supervisor: Dr. Kuaifei Xia) 2021

Thesis: Non-coding RNAs ciR133 and miR168a-5p play roles in response to Xoo and abiotic stress in rice, respectively

PUBLICATIONS

- **Pan X***, Kelani AA*, Schrettenbrunner L, Prabakar S, Israni B, Blango MG. (2026). An improved description of the small RNA landscape of the human fungal pathogen *Aspergillus fumigatus*. Mol Microbiol 1-12.
- **Pan X***, Bruch A*, Blango MG. (2024). The past, present, and future of RNA modifications in infectious disease research. ACS Infect Dis 10(12), 4017-4029.
- Xia K*, **Pan X***, Chen H, Xu X, Zhang M. (2023). X00-responsive transcriptome reveals the role of the circular RNA133 in disease resistance by regulating expression of OsARAB in rice. Phytopathol Res 5, 22.
- Xia K*, **Pan X***, Zeng X, Zhang M. (2023). Rice miR168a-5p regulates seed length, nitrogen allocation and salt tolerance by targeting OsOFP3, OsNPF2.4, and OsAGO1a, respectively. J. Plant Physiol 208, 153905.
- Kelani AA, Bruch A, Riviaccio F, Visser C, Krüger T, Weaver D, **Pan X**, Schaeuble S, Panagiotou G, Kniemeyer O, Bromley MJ, Bowyer P, Barber AE, Brakhage AA, Blango MG. (2023). Disruption of the *A. fumigatus* RNA interference machinery alters the conidial transcriptome. RNA 29(7), 1033-1050.

CONFERENCES

- **2025 - Oral presentation:** German speaking Mycological Society (DMykG), Germany
- **2025 - Poster:** Gordon Research Seminar - RNA Editing, Italy
- **2024 - Oral presentation:** Jena RNA Club Symposium, Germany
- **2024 - Poster:** RNA Society Meeting, UK
- **2023 - Poster:** EMBL - The Non-coding Genome Symposium, Germany

AWARDS & SCHOLARSHIP

- DAAD Scholarship 2021 - 2025
- Jena School for Microbial Communication (JSMC) travel grant 2023

REFEREE

- Dr. Matthew Blango (matthew.blango@leibniz-hki.de)
- Dr. Olaf Kniemeyer (olaf.kniemeyer@leibniz-hki.de)